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Burrill Crohn

Burrill Crohn is a documentary filmmaker and owner of Jazz Images, Inc. His films include the five-part "History of Jazz" series, "Women in Jazz," and a concert documentary, "Joe Williams/A Portrait in Song." Burrill's interests extend beyond the jazz world, and his current project is entitled "Playing with Parkinson's," about musician Sangeeta Michael Berardi facing the challenge of Parkinson's disease.

Burrill was interviewed on January 3, 2012 in Woodstock, NY, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and I'm interviewing for the Jazz Archive at Hamilton College, in Woodstock. And I'm happy to have Burrill Crohn with me, who is usually on the other side of the camera.

BC: I could still do it if you want.

MR: You could do it. And we could get a cardboard cutout of you.

BC: Well I could use my body double.

MR: You know those terms. I just had to laugh at myself because we were doing an audio check and instead of going "check one two three four" you had all the other numbers. I don't know if that's from hearing "one two three four" too often.

BC: Of course it is. It's also the magic numbers. You know I just uttered a secret formula that allowed me to double myself so I could be behind the camera at the same time.

MR: Could I have you repeat the little phrase you said when you got your Ace award, which you just told me about.

BC: Sure.

MR: I liked it.

BC: So in 1987 I won an Ace award which is the cable equivalent of an Emmy. Back then they had Emmys for broadcast television, and the Ace for cable television. A couple of years later they merged and became the same thing, but it was the same thing. The crowded theater in Hollywood, the searchlights outside, tuxedos, you know. And so I won it as a writer for my "History of Jazz" series, before Ken Burns, and so what I said was — I practiced this — was that I thanked all the people you're supposed to thank — David Chertok, the film collector, Wynton Marsalis, Chick Corea, Branford — good move Monk.

MR: Sorry.

BC: Should I keep going?

BC: Yeah. So real quick I'll sum up. Back then the Ace awards were for cable and Emmys were for broadcast television, because they merged them. It was the same type of ceremony, broadcast on HBO. Searchlights, tuxedos, crowded theater everything. And I won it as a writer. And I was very nervous and I'd rehearsed an acceptance speech. And I got up in front of the crowd. The first thing I said is this is the wrong side of a camera for a writer to be on. But then I thanked all the people, David Chertok, the film collector, Branford Marsalis, Wynton Marsalis, Chick Corea and the people I work with. And then I said, "And I want to thank jazz itself, born in the U.S.A. a hundred years ago, and re-born every time someone takes a solo."

MR: Nicely said.

BC: And deeply felt.

MR: And you are player yourself?

BC: Of sorts.

MR: I actually haven't introduced you on the film quite yet, for those people who will be watching us. Do you call yourself a documentary filmmaker?

BC: I call myself a documentary filmmaker, yeah.

MR: And you wear different hats as a writer.

BC: Well I can do all the things involved with making a film. If I have enough money I don't want to do any of them, I just hire people. But the way things have gone, these days you have to do everything almost.

MR: I had this thought earlier today when we were with Warren Bernhardt, and then thinking about what you do and what he does, and a little bit of what I do, and that we sort of live on the fringe. But I think it's important.

BC: I don't think Warren lives on the fringe. Warren is right in the center of existence.

MR: Okay.

BC: I mean as he says, he's a blessed person, and everything he does seems to turn out right no matter what he does. I mean what he says, how he plays, where he's been, the things that have just happened to him in life, it's like this is a blessed existence. I'm sure he has his ups and downs like everybody else, but man, what a life.

MR: Yeah. Born under the piano so to speak.

BC: Born under the piano so to speak. So I don't think Warren is on the fringe of anything. But the rest of us —

MR: Well I have to wonder, I have asked musicians what led them to such an occupation, and I'll ask you the same thing. Why do you do what you do?

BC: Okay. You mentioned that I'm a player. I love to play when I play. I first became aware of the sound of the trumpet at the same time I became aware of sex. It was just about the

daydream, that someone would give me a trumpet and I'd be able to pick it up and play it. And it didn't turn out like that. And I went to college and the guy down the hall had a trumpet, and I used to listen to him practice, and when he left he gave me a mouthpiece and an Alban book, which is the classical book for studying. And I basically taught myself to play. I took my fingering out of the chart in the Alban book. Anyway but I always loved music. And I realized after a while that I was not good. I could play but I wasn't that good. But the love of music never went away. And I listened to jazz and I'd go hear jazz, and, as Warren says, jazz touched my heart. And I listened to classical music, but it was jazz that touched my heart. So I actually began life, after a couple of false starts in different areas, as a writer. And I used to write educational materials. And gradually, as the medium for educational materials switched from print to multimedia, I started writing different multimedia forms, including films, for instance slide shows. And then when the first portapak video cameras came out in the early seventies, I picked up one of the first portapaks and I just go oh I want to do this. And somewhere along the line I got the dream of I want to make documentaries and I want to make documentaries about music, about jazz. And it was just a whole new vision — call it something from inside — I wanted to do this. And I didn't know anything about filmmaking.

MR: Was there a model for you? Things to look at?

BC: No. I mean the more I started doing it the more I looked at other people's work. But I'll just finish, so I happened to know someone at what was then called ABC Video Enterprises, which was the forerunner of Arts & Entertainment Network. And I went to them — I think I contacted David Chertok, the film collector. I saw an article about him in the *New York Times*. And I went to him and I said, "David, let's do a history of jazz series together." It was very bold, I'd never made a film. Oh I take it back, I take it back. So I went to this guy and I said I wanted to do a history of jazz series. Come to think of it I had contacted David, and I even gave him, which was silly, a deposit, like an advance against some of the work so that he wouldn't work with anybody else, he'd do this with me. And then I went to A&E, this guy I knew, and I said, "Let's do a history of jazz series." And he went to his bosses. And at this time, it was very interesting — A&E during the day broadcasts women's programming — beauty shows, health shows. And at night they did cultural programs. So their bosses came back to me and said, "How about doing a women in jazz series?" And I knew a lot about jazz but I didn't really know about women in jazz but I figured I'll find out. So I said okay, I'll do that. And that led to the first thing I did which was a series of "Women in Jazz" narrated by Marian McPartland for the instrumental side, and Carmen McRae for the vocal side. And that played for a long time. But I didn't know what I was doing. I learned as I went along. Remember

MR: He was on board for that.

BC: Billy — I showed him the clip of Wynton Marsalis, he was directing that shoot. And I remember saying, "Billy, what's time code?" I didn't even know what time code was when I started. But somehow I bluffed my way through and it came out okay. And I wrote them and I produced them and I directed them, and blah-blah-blah. So I just had this vision that this was what I wanted to do, and I learned as I went along.

MR: How did it feel the first time you saw the scroll with your name on it.

BC: It felt great. Warren was talking about his parents. My parents were not quite the same way. I remember I went down to where my parents were living at the time and I put on this station and I played this show. My parents never — my father would play classical music. He hated jazz. He hated my playing the trumpet jazz. And when — it was a half hour show I showed him and then the scrolls showed up, written and directed by Burrill Crohn. I was in my forties then. And he said, "Very nice. Too bad it took you so long to do it." A knife into my heart.

MR: Oh gee.

BC: After that, the first time you see your name on television it's a big thrill. After that it just comes routine.

MR: Nowadays we can talk about jazz education, we can have the same conversation about film education. Do people need to go to film school?

BC: You know these days, because people are so computer literate and so many programs make it easy to do anything, I think kids come out of grade school or out of secondary school, if they have any interest in video at all they can do digital editing, they've shot on cameras. I mean I think if you want to go make feature films there's two reasons to go to film schools. You do learn a lot and you get a lot of hands-on experience, and you make great contacts. You work on other people's films, they work on yours, and when the time comes when the people get a Hollywood contract they call their friends to work on the film. I never was good in school at anything. I always had to learn my own way.

MR: Was your degree in writing?

BC: Comparative literature — with a minor in psychology.

MR: I like — you used the term "film strips" I can remember the beep — turn the dial.

BC: Exactly. And after a while they became automated to the beep would activate the slide projector.

MR: Not to get too off the track but it's amazing how much technology has changed in a brief fifty years.

BC: Astounding. I mean just — we were talking about looking up things on YouTube, just Google. I mean if you want to do any research you had to go to the library and go through

that alone is an astounding revolution. I mean I used to have reference *Encyclopedia Brittanica*s and this book and dictionaries, and my desk was surrounded by them. Now I'm surrounded by hard drives and computers.

MR: And what do you think of that?

BC: Oh I think it's 90 percent good and 10 percent I think bad, because I think the sense of scholarship is lost. I used to teach jazz history up at RPI. And I realized people can find things so easily, and they take what they find on YouTube or on the 'net — the first thing that comes up is their primary source and they don't dig any deeper. I mean you must run into that at Hamilton. And so they don't get really immersed in the subject. It's a little bit like some people say about the difference between working in video and film. In film you've got something concrete that you have your hands on, something, it's a physical, tangible thing. Looking up stuff in the library and reading books is a physical — there's something about the medium, there's something tangible. I don't know whether you take it in more. I'm not sure about all that. But I still prefer reading books than reading e-books. And it's a little bit of the same thing. I love the ease of the computer. I can do things, edit on the computer, with a little 15, 17, 18 hundred dollar laptop and a program that now costs about three hundred dollars, that I was spending about three hundred dollars an hour to edit on back in the eighties. And that's astounding. But you don't have that intimacy.

MR: Yeah. I think there's something to be said for smelling the book mold in a library. And it's very easy to sound old fashioned, like oh come on get with it. But the effort you have to make to go somewhere, and do the research, to me there's value to it.

BC: Well it's a little bit like I remember going to a — I don't gamble and I'm not interested in casinos, but I went to see a magician I knew play in Atlantic City at a casino. I forgot which one. And it's a 24-hour environment. They have trees and they have waterfalls and things like that. And it's like there'll come a time in our life when that will be our environment and we'll forget what a tree looks like, or smells like. And maybe not. Maybe things will change. I think the pendulum has swung too far and technology may be the ruination of us and the world may collapse in a certain way because of technology, and then the pendulum will swing back to whatever is left of earth and we will gain wisdom instead of intelligence and technology. Because what we gain in technology I think we lose in wisdom.

MR: Wow. I'm glad that's going to be written down. That's a good statement.

BC: Okay.

MR: How about your experience hearing jazz live in clubs? Did it happen early on for you?

BC: Yes. I mean as soon as I was old enough to get into a club, and even when I couldn't.

very young, and there was jazz everywhere in New York back then. And my early taste was to swing, because the people I listened to were the big bands and Harry James. I remember finding an early recording of Harry James where he played a great recording. He played in a small group in Chicago. It was unbelievable, that small group stuff. And I remember going to 52nd Street and hearing Wilbur and Sidney DeParis. You know who they are. And then, but then I heard Roy Eldridge and I actually heard Bird before he died, just once in a little club, what was it called, I can't remember. I know it was on the corner of Third and MacDougal — The Open Door. That's what it's called. And as I grew older I heard a lot of people. I heard Mingus and Monk. I heard Coltrane.

MR: Can you recall, at the time, however old you were, were you aware that you were listening to legendary people?

BC: Excellent question, excellent question. No I don't think so, looking back. By the time I first heard Miles I knew he was legendary. I heard Miles at Café Bohemia. But by and large — and the other thing was you could go out and hear the legends but you could also go hear someone you never heard of play just as good and by whatever chance of fate or their own personality they never made it quote, the way the others did. I've talked to musicians who have stories who have traveled all over the country — they'll go to a little club somewhere in a nowhere town and they hear a musician as great as anybody you'd ever hear. So there are a lot of geniuses out there that never saw the light of day. So I'm not sure how I felt. Because I grew up at a point where some of the people I heard were already becoming legendary like Monk and Mingus, so I was a little swayed by that. At the same time they were still young men. It's sort of like a little bit of each.

MR: At what point did you start going to live things and looking at them as a cameraman, or as a future documentary filmmaker.

BC: Not until I started doing it I don't think. I mean I really didn't think that way until I suddenly got the urge. I did a film in 1981, it had nothing to do with jazz, it was called Anne Frank and Maine. A friend of mine was teaching the Holocaust at a little school with Gentile children in Maine, and he brought in the Holocaust as curriculum. And I thought that was just brilliant. And so I pitched the Anti-Defamation League and I got some money to go up there and make a film. And I didn't shoot or anything at that time, I hired a crew. And I still remember the cameraman I hired and I saw him holding a camera and I saw him shooting, and I said I want to do that. And for the first time he let me hold a camera, oh it felt like so natural. But then he said, I just remember he said, "Shooting is one thing, but that's the easy part. Lighting. That's the art. Lighting is where the art comes in." But I used to dream of having a camera. And then the first documentaries I did I did not shoot, I directed. And they had these beautiful cameras,

three chip cameras, we shot on one inch tape back then. But I just had a vision of myself having one of these and walking around the street. And one thing led to another and eventually — it was not that one but something like that. But it wasn't until I started shooting on the portapak that I got a taste of doing that. But it wasn't for a while until, actually the budgets changed and I had to learn how to do this myself.

MR: Well it's funny because when you said the cameraman said that it's not the shooting it's the — I thought you were going to say editing.

BC: Well that's true. And as any camera person will tell you if you know editing you're already thinking about the editing when you're shooting. But you know it's interesting. I'm a classic ADD person. Oh God we're going to go on a sideline here. Someone said that ADD was a useful trait before the Industrial Revolution, back when we were hunters and gatherers. Gatherers did repetitive tasks and they had to be aware in the future that if they planted their seeds and they knew their tasks in the spring would yield dividends in the fall. So they were like they were of the mentality of they could see into the future, they knew that repetitive tasks were good. The hunters had to be alert every moment, and went out in the forest, and the sound of a broken twig, or the movement, they had to be alert and ready to shoot. And I'm actually a fairly good cameraman, I think because — and also ADD people need to use their body and move around. They can't be just in their head. Using their body grounds themselves. So when I'm with a camera I feel grounded. And I used to shoot rifles and I'm a good shot. I was very accurate as a marksman. And when you hold a camera and you move it, you feel one with the camera, you feel one with your environment, it's like being a hunter. And one eye's looking for what is coming up and the other eye is with the camera, and I feel more grounded, more alive, when I'm shooting as a cameraman than almost anything that I do. Because I'm using my brain and my body. I'm using my eye. I'm using all parts of my consciousness and my body and it's where all the elements come together.

MR: It sounds a little bit like jazz improvisation.

BC: It is in a way and that's a good point. I never made it as a musician but when you're shooting you're improvising all the time. And I also think that, as Warren would say, "Everything is everything. We're all related." Editing is also, you don't create the piece, you wait for the piece to emerge and speak to you. What you're editing. Rodin once said, "The sculpture is in the stone waiting to be revealed." You don't chip away and create something, it's already in there. You just let it speak to you and you know where to chip. And out comes the sculpture that is already in there. And when I edit, if I don't get too cerebral about it, I realize the film is in there. Now it's footage, but somewhere the film is in there waiting to be — and you have to work really hard at clearing the debris around it

patience. I happen to be editing something now and I can't do it on a part time thing. I have to clear away my life. I have to make sure there's enough money that I don't have to go out — because once you plunge into editing — it's like writers talk about writing a book, they just plunge into writing a book. Joyce Carol Oates once said, "You don't water the plants, you don't dust your house, you don't vacuum, you just write."

MR: Do you have to have a script to start a film?

BC: No. Not at all. Au contraire. Well there are two types of documentaries. I take that back. The "History of Jazz" series I did we did have scripts. It was almost like the classical way of doing a documentary, you put index cards and one colored card is for the footage, the other colored card is for narration. And what we did before that, so much was based on the archival film clips we had, that the narration I wrote simply as a way to time together the clips. Like the clips were the gems on the tiara. [Ding] Ding. Fourth floor. Ladies' Lingerie. The narration was the tiara which holds it. So in that case you basically follow the narration. But I don't like to do a narration I like the film to create, in that case, no there is no script. And then you try to — the script emerges out of the video clips. They become a sequence in which the story is told.

MR: Let's talk about the logistics, the reality. Because earlier today we were talking about someone who wanted to make a film about Bill Frisell, and I remember I forget now, I wanted to write it down.

BC: Let me put in a plug for her. Her name is Emma Franz, it's F-R-A-N-Z, and she's a jazz singer out of Australia, but she did this incredible film called "Intangible Assets Number 82" about an Australian drummer, Simon Baker, who was captivated by the sound of a Korean shaman. Shamans use drums to go into a trance. It was a shamanic drummer who is legendary. And he did many pilgrimages to try to see him and none of them ever quite worked. And she managed to go on one trip with a great crew, it's a beautifully shot film. I'll show you later. And she finally made the pilgrimage and met the drummer. And the shaman drummer died a couple of hours later — a couple of days later, not a couple of hours later. She is now doing a film on Bill Frisell.

MR: And you said, I can't remember the words, but you were referring to finding funding, like a hard nut.

BC: You know I don't know what they teach in film school because I didn't go to film school, but the first thing they should do it teach us fundraising. I'm doing a film now that I think is going to be a wonderful film about a musician with Parkinson's disease. The filmmaking is the easy part. The fundraising is the tough part. I have to stop and get something to drink.

MR: I have a bottle of water actually.

BC: Oh, if you could give me the bottle of water. Thank you so much. Are you putting on the headphone every now and then just to see whether the sound — you should see whether it still sounds good. My voice is getting raspy.

MR: I'm hearing me.

BC: No now you should hear me, how does that sound?

MR: Yeah, sounds good.

BC: Good. That was good to check. Here's another little thing. In film school everyone teaches how to make video film and sometimes kids go away thinking that's all there is. If you don't get good sound, you're screwed. Good sound can rescue bad video. You can never rescue bad sound.

MR: I understand what you're saying. And I noticed that, even in commercials or sometimes TV shows and you can tell when things have been vocally overdubbed. And sometimes I wonder, why do they have to do that?

BC: Probably they didn't have good sound.

MR: Right.

BC: But if you get good authentic sound, you can get the worse picture, but if the sound is good it'll save — it won't totally compensate, but you can get a lot of compensation if you've got good sound. But if you don't have good sound I don't care how good the picture is, people won't want to hear that.

MR: Well getting back to this, it's almost step one, you get this idea and then you have to find some funding. Now you've got to research, right?

BC: Well things have changed. Everything's changing. Like technology is changing, information is changing, everything is changing. When I first started doing films, first of all budgets were bigger, because the price of entry was much more expensive. You are shooting on a camera that costs about three thousand dollars, if my memory serves me. I was shooting on cameras that cost seventy thousand dollars. Editing was three or four hundred dollars an hour, or you could edit off-line for fifty or seventy dollars an hour. But you have to go back to 1980s prices, which was double that today. And now you can edit on laptops, so everything is changing. Secondly, so therefore, if you could find sponsors, when I started doing the "Women in Jazz" I went to A&E and A&E paid for stuff. They paid for me, they ended up owning the footage, but I got paid for what I did. When I got the idea — no I didn't get the idea, Leslie Gourse got the idea — but for those who are watching, I did a film on Joe Williams, a documentary on Joe Williams that Monk was very involved in and it actually came to me, but that was paid for by Hamilton College. And when I did the "History of Jazz" series I went to Japan. I spent a week in Japan negotiating a contract with what was then — it was the Japanese back

something about jazz. It was a big contract. It was like a half a million dollar contract to do a ten episode series on the history of jazz. David Chertok had set that up actually. And I spent a week in Japan with an attorney, sitting at a conference table with the Japanese. That was funny in itself because they had a translator there, and they would say something in Japanese and then translate it, and then we'd talk among ourselves, and then come up with our answer. And they would translate back to me. After a couple of days we realized they knew English as good as we did, but they were listening to what we were saying. But anyway, today like everything else is changing and like even Occupy Wall Street and Arab Spring and all that, that's breaking down the hierarchy and everything is going more vertical. We're turning to each other. Kickstarter — you know about Kickstarter?

MR: Yeah.

BC: Well Kickstarter, you look at all the stuff that's being funded on Kickstarter, that's people turning to each other for money. And I am doing this film — I need a lot more than what I've raised — but I raised eleven thousand dollars on Kickstarter, that helped me do a critical recording session with Sangeeta — the musician with Parkinson's — and able-bodied musicians that he used to play with — a very critical part of the film. But I'm struggling now. I go to people, I ask people for money. I've gotten shameless. I mean what I really want is to have a producer come in and handle this part for me. But that's hard to find, especially on a film like this that'll probably not make a lot of money if it even makes its own money back. So I have to ask everyone for money, and do you need a tax write-off?

MR: It's like Warren was saying about that next step up of being a band leader.

BC: Exactly. Exactly. He never wanted to do it. Exactly.

MR: Smart.

BC: You know I find I'm happier working with other people and okay, Burrill you do this part and you'll do that part, rather than where I have to do everything myself. And I'm — hey, look at me, I'm not young anymore. And it gets hard.

MR: Do you find that it behooves you to be aware of what you have to pay for — licensing and royalties and all that.

BC: Oh sure. Oh sure. And you know even though I'm not terribly organized, I have spreadsheet programs where I put all the — some of it you have to guess at — but sure, when you raise money that's part of what you raise money for. You have the whole overhead thing. You need an accountant. You need an attorney to advise you. You need someone to look over the releases and see if they're okay, and then the music clearances, which — as you and I both know very well — we did this documentary on Joe Williams

good, because I just got out of the way and let Joe be himself. But it will never be seen on television unless we raise another fifty grand or so to clear all the music licenses and pay the Basie orchestra what they get — scale for television, which is a different thing from playing in a concert hall. And all this extra money has to be raised. So yeah.

MR: Yeah, Jean Bach, "A Great Day in Harlem."

BC: Oh I know Jean, I know her editor, Sue Peehl very well.

MR: Yeah. She said, "Yeah, go ahead and make your film, just don't put any music in it."

BC: That's right. That's right. Make your film and don't put any music in it, that's exactly right. Or make your film and hire a composer to write the music.

MR: Oh, yeah. Do you think people get the wrong idea, like oh you're making a film, you're going to make a lot of money on your film — I said a joke didn't I?

BC: Well yes and no. First of all, there are exceptions to every rule. And you know I'm crying poor here, but there was a period in my life when I did the "History of Jazz" series, there was a market for jazz films. And I had what they call a syndicator in England. He had a company called TCB, meaning taking care of business. His name was Angus Trowbridge — it's a great British name — but he was an American and he lived outside of London. And he would go around to Cannes and different names of film festivals where buyers come, TV sent representatives and they come, and they buy. So he would only have jazz films. That's what TCB was about. And he had these whole bunch of jazz films and he'd sell a package: okay you have two of Burrill's films and three of this film and three of that film, and you'd buy the whole package. And then he would sell it, he'd take twenty-five percent for himself, and he'd send checks. And they would come in the mail. That was great. So I got paid for doing the film, and then we got paid afterwards. So nowadays — and of course there are always people like Ken Burns — Ken Burns makes money when he does — he makes money whatever he does. And I also mentioned, when you first contacted me, about being the first person, as a jazz filmmaker, I said I'm not the first person you should be interviewing. The first one is Bruce Ricker, who did "Last of the Blue Devils" and then he went on to become friends with Clint Eastwood. He did "Straight, No Chaser," and he did a wonderful film on Louie Prima, and he did one on Harold Arlen and he did some beautiful films, and he made money from doing them. And then there's Don McGlynn who's probably the most prolific jazz filmmaker, "Mingus" and — oh I take it back, I take it back — it's Don McGlynn who did Louie Prima and Harold Arlen and Mingus and Horace Parlan and Howlin' Wolf. But Bruce did a couple of American Masters — he did one on Tony Bennett, that's what he did, a really good film on Tony Bennett. So Don McGlynn and Bruce Ricker both did okay in jazz, and Don is very much alive and very prolific and still making films. He is a very good person

knowledgeable. He's just a good guy all around and he's been very prolific. And he always finds money to make films. I don't think he makes a lot of money when he makes them, but then the TV sales and — well you'd have to talk to him. I don't know what his economic thing is.

MR: How do you get included in getting those residuals or whatever. Is that something that you have in a contract?

BC: No that depends. Like when I did the film for Hamilton College, there was nothing. You hired me as the director and producer and I did it. When I first did the "History of Jazz" series, we basically sold it off. Like when we got money from Japan they got Japanese rights and that's all they got. And they could screen it in Japan, but then we had the rights to sell it in other parts of the world. The "History of Jazz" series I did has been seen in something like forty countries around the world. And the BBC, back then they paid big money for jazz films, I mean twenty, twenty-five thousand dollars. I was on BRAVO, I think they paid ten, eleven thousand dollars. It adds up. But we kept the rights to sell it in different places. I look at the distribution now, it's very high. Distribution is changing all the time. You can distribute on the net. You have webcasts, you do — maybe you have to put up a site, I don't even know how I'm going to distribute this film.

MR: When you heard about — did you know about Ken Burns' thing before it was aired?

BC: Yes. They even came to me. Somebody from Ken Burns' office called me up and said, "Let's have lunch." And I said ooh, maybe there's something in it for me. And on the phone I said I'd love to — if you need someone to produce some segments I'd love to do it. "Oh no, we have people to do that." They didn't want it. They just wanted to pick my brain. They didn't offer me anything.

MR: Someone recommended our interviews too and it didn't go anywhere.

BC: Right. No Ken Burns, as someone said, Ken Burns gets all the money, which isn't very nice, but he's like this big boat. It's like if you're paddling someplace and this big tanker comes through, it upsets the little boats. He also takes all the money that might be reserved for us other little filmmakers, whatever money there is for jazz.

MR: Right. What did you think of his jazz film?

BC: I'm saying this on camera for posterity. It just had some problems with it. I think, if I remember correctly, he had a thing on Bird and there's only one clip of Bird, at the time anyway, the Hothouse clip with Dizzy and all that. And there's one thirty-two bar chorus of Bird on film. And he cuts it off after the bridge if I remember correctly. And I think I threw a shoe at the TV set. I might be wrong about that. I remember I think he did cut into it with narration, he cut it off. I mean you don't cut in to a Bird solo when it's the only one there is on film. And there are other things.

BC: Also, he didn't know anything about jazz when he started.

MR: That's what irked me to start with.

BC: So he relied on Stanley Crouch and Wynton Marsalis, and, you know, God bless both of them, they've done a lot for jazz and I respect Stanley as a writer and I certainly respect Wynton, because I've worked with Wynton and he's got an incredible mind. But he wasn't immersed. It's like, you know when you're immersed in the music from the way up you would have made a different film than you would if you had just come to it new and have to learn it while you're doing it.

MR: In that film, and in other places, when I read about jazz, I sometimes object to the idea that changes in music, jazz especially, are often because of social issues. To me they leave out the thing about people just experiment because they can, and because it feels good to do something new, or — Evan Christopher, who's a clarinetist we've had at the college, had this interesting theory about why vibrato with the early New Orleans clarinetists, and it had to do with playing with out of tune pianos. You know, that kind.

BC: Wait a minute. There's vibrato and there's vibrato. You have the vibrato of the clarinetist and then you have Sidney Bechet, which brought vibrato to a whole other level. He made vibrato an art form.

MR: Right. He surely did.

BC: I'm not sure I agree with that. I think that — did you ever read a book called — we were talking about this, how both of us are losing things — *Jazz: A People's Music*?

MR: I think I did. LeRoi Jones?

BC: No, no, no, no, no. It's a Marxist historian. It's a very interesting book. It's about music and social change and I found it a fascinating book when I read it. And I also think that if you look at the arts, I think everything is interconnected. I think that World War II, there was an innocence pre-World War II. World War II came, with the advent of the bomb, and with a sense all of us made for the first time that we could face extinction. That gave rise to a different form of literature, the existentialist writings and I think music changed also. There's another thing, I really believe this, look at Bird and Dizzy, who were just phenomenal technicians. Now these are musicians who might have tried out for symphony orchestras but — would have wanted to try out for symphony orchestras but they never would get a chance. So whether it was conscious or unconscious, they developed their chops to an unbelievable degree. And then they had these cutting sessions and they'd take tempos at 320 or something like that, and say, "Okay white boy, come in and try to — you think you're such good players, try to play this." So whether that's a conscious force or any unconscious force — or take what happened in World War I, when the 369th regiment band, James Reese Europe's marching band came and they went

partially because France was a colonial power. And they had a percent of African music in their DNA almost, let alone within their culture. So they saw black musicians as a carrier of a tradition from Africa, whereas America looked at black musicians as, what was jazz, this was like a sexual act. It was like lowbrow music. It was — oh it doesn't qualify — all the rants against jazz will deprave you, it'll make your children depraved, and all that stuff. But in France they recognized this music as an offshoot to African music. And the black musicians — women threw themselves at them, people brought them drinks, and a lot of them stayed after the war was over, in Paris and in France in general and in Europe, and they invited their friends to come over. And then the first jazz criticism was written by Frenchmen. And they helped Americans appreciate their own art form. So I don't think musical development or any art form — there were people in the Vanguard who were ahead of the curve — like Bird was or Coltrane — but some of that's spiritual. I think they're in touch with the spiritual. You know you listen to a lot of musicians, and writers say this too and painters, some of they say, "It's not me that's doing the playing, this is something that passes through me." I tune my own instrument, my body, my technique, just like you make a radio as pure as you can to receive transmissions that come through it. You make your own instrument as pure as you can so what comes through from some other planet or wherever music comes from, passes through you. It's amazing how many quote famous musicians would say it's not me playing, I'm just passing it on. So I think it's all connected — history and social movements and spiritual stuff, and there are so many factors that come into play. I'm doing this film on this musician with Parkinson's. I met him in the street and after talking to him for an hour I just got this message, I've got to make the film on this guy. I mean he lives in California but he happened to be here because he used to live here and he was visiting. I was talking in the street with Marc Black who is the musician that Warren was talking about who plays so loud sometimes. And here's how things interconnect. We were talking about a Warren Bernhardt concert. Warren had just gave a concert at the Kleinert. And we were talking on the street about the concert the night before. I actually remember this. We were talking about the Rachmaninoff preludes. Apparently there are twenty-four. I didn't know this. And Marc was saying there are twenty-four because each one is in every key in the major and minor of every key and that's why there are twenty-four. And Sangeeta was sitting on a bench and he was looking at us and he's in his seventies and he's small and he was looking at us. And he got up and said — he sort of walked funny and came over and says, "Excuse me, you guys talking about music?" And we said yeah. He says, "Can I join you?" And then he started talking, and within two hours, Marc left and I knew that it was like getting a message from God. I had to make a

film about this guy. So here I am. I don't know how I'm doing it and whether I can raise enough money to finish it — I will.

MR: But you got the inspiration which is step one, right?

BC: That's right. And sometimes — we're going to get far out here — inspiration is like getting pregnant. It's like something, some idea comes and impregnates you. And then you've given birth to this thing and you have to nurture this thing into being, into adulthood, which is the finished film. I don't have children of my own, as far as I know, and someone has said, "Yeah but you have your films" which is your children. Each one of them came to me as an idea and I nurtured them into being and let them loose into the world. And they'll be there long after I'm gone, for better or for worse.

MR: And not just jazz films. I saw on your web site —

BC: Uh oh.

MR: I saw a picture of you in Ecuador? In the jungle?

BC: Yeah.

MR: Wow.

BC: Well I happen to have a big interest in shamanism. And so I've done research in that area and ah blah-blah-blah. I've shot shamans in different countries. And that particular thing was some people I knew were going down to make a recording of the music and dance of the Shuars. See that picture over there of the guy with the painted face and everything? That's a Shuar, they're an indigenous tribe of Ecuador in the rain forest. And they have their own — I'll give you a CD — they have their music which is — their songs are all sacred. They have songs for planting, songs for hunting, songs for fishing. Icaros I think is the term, that forms a prayer before they do any activity. So I went down to film the making of this CD, which was their songs. And I've shot shamans in different parts of the world and stuff like that. This is a whole other interest of mine — spiritual things, healers, I'm very interested in healers because I think they are the medicine of the future. They're the medicine of the past and the medicine of the future. Even pharmaceutical companies go in the rain forest to rob the plants and patent the compounds and we use them as this great medication. I'm so sorry.

MR: It's an interesting outlook. Because I know you have medical — your uncle was very well known, right?

BC: My name is Burrill L. Crohn and my uncle's name was Burrill B. Crohn, and he is the — not the inventor but he correctly identified the cluster of symptoms as being misdiagnosed as Crohn's disease. And so yeah, so I bear that name, which is interesting. There is a connection there somehow. Everyone thought I should be a doctor and I wasn't interested, but I am interested in healing.

MR: So what's the best circumstances you've ever been shooting at — the most — like everything came together. I mean I know what I thought.

BC: Tell me.

MR: Well the Joe Williams film was — I'll never forget that moment when, for those people who are watching, we filmed the Basie band with Joe Williams at the college. And that night, when everything finally came together and the band started and I was standing there with nothing to do.

BC: Because you had done everything else up to then.

MR: I had no idea what to do but I was like so overwhelmed at that time with all these booms going all over the place and the place was overflowing. I remember we had to find another room and we fed a thing to the camera so these people could watch it. Like wow, this was fantastic.

BC: Yeah, I love the Joe Williams film, and I love showing it. And to me, see you stopped working then but I didn't. I was nervous, I was in the control room. And then we still had to edit and everything. But I'm very happy with what came out, though I look at it and I wish I had Joe for a longer period of time. We only had him for two days and there was a lot more things I would have liked to have gotten. But I think it works. But you know I look at the film I did on Fathead [Newman] which is just a very short thing. I think that's beautiful because it captured Fathead. So I don't know, and there are things that will never see the light of day but something just came together. It's the same thing I talk about making — people talk about making music. Sometimes I'm shooting, just shooting, and something takes over and it's not me that's doing the shooting, I'm just getting what I'm meant to be getting. That sometimes happens in editing too. So I'm not sure that it's any one thing, but there are moments that just come together. When I was shooting the shamans in Ecuador and there's a scene where they're hunting with blowguns, and there's just some footage in there that's beautiful. And somehow it's beautiful because everything came together just right. Or they're fishing with their hands and the rushing water is going by and I'm holding the camera an inch from the water while they're fishing with their hands. So I think you just get into the moment sometimes and whether it all makes it into a finished film or not, I don't know.

MR: Did you ever have moments where you are saying why am I doing this?

BC: Oh yeah, of course. Of course. If I knew how to do anything else I'd probably be doing something else. I mean raising money, I'm getting older and running on location and doing this and producing this and worrying and this and that. But no, Warren talks about feeling blessed. I don't think I've had the sort of like blessed life Warren had, where he started listening to music under the piano hearing Rubenstein playing. But I feel blessed

on television, has been about music. And there is something about — I don't think I'm a great filmmaker at all. I mean there are people with way better technical chops than me. But if I love it, it seems to come out better. If I don't love it, it doesn't come out good at all. So I'm not good at doing commercials or doing industrial films, because if I don't love it, there are twenty people that do it better than me — a hundred and twenty people — twelve hundred people.

MR: What are technical chops in filmmaking?

BC: Oh I don't know, lighting and sound, and you know, image and effects. I don't know. There's a lot of stuff you have to learn, and I never learned it in film school so I'm always learning it as I go along. But that's the way I learn. But I love learning like that.

MR: Don't you feel you could at least be a guest at a film school?

BC: Just like you said that you — well you know you've had me out, I've guest lectured at film — I don't know. They tend to go, I don't know, I tend to put myself down so I don't know. But I'm older, as you went through, you try for a teaching job and you may be too old for the teaching job, and you don't have advanced degrees and I don't have film school degrees. I've had certain experiences that I think can be valuable to impart — to pass on. I think I'm probably more valuable for some filmmaker to just call me up and ask me questions about stuff, because I don't know if I lectured it at a film school whether it would be of interest to everybody. I believe education is where someone seeks out the person with knowledge, not where the person with knowledge comes and tells you what they think you need to learn. But sure, anybody that's older has been through a lot of stuff and has something to impart. That's the tradition of the elders in tribal communities. Instead of us getting older and being marginalized as we grow older, there's a culture where there the elders are important. They may not be able to do everything they did when they were young, but they have accumulated wisdom to pass on.

MR: Are there jazz people out there now that you would like to focus on with a film, or a group of them?

BC: I think the last time I really was moved and wanted to do a film about a jazz person image was Clifford Brown. And that was twenty years ago. I really wanted to do that film, because I loved Clifford's playing. And who he was as a man. He ran sort of counter to the prevailing jazz of the fifties, which was people who were debauched, they did heroin and you'd see people playing and nodding off while they're playing. And he was a mathematician, he was a chess player, he was a clean liver, he was a beautiful, sweet soul, and he died not of an overdose. I mean there's a history of trumpet players dying young. Bix Beiderbecke from drink; Bunny Berigan from drink.

BC: Fats Navarro from drugs. Lee Morgan from being killed on the bandstand. I mean, and in the face of all that, there's Clifford you know, full of life, cut down by a car accident. So I want to capture that goodness on film. I really want to make a film about Clifford and shoot in places where he played and interview the people who knew him. That's the last film I really had a love in my heart to do. I do with Sangeeta but he just was presented to me. I didn't know who Sangeeta was. So I have more call to do films now on healers and shamans and spiritual people. Or not do films at all. I mean, you know, it's time to move on and do something else. Somebody asked me about — I said the only thing worse about the film I'm making on Sangeeta, because it's been very hard, making this film on Sangeeta, is not making this film on Sangeeta. Because I really do love him and making the film, it's just very hard. And I don't know what I'd be doing if I weren't doing it. We've certainly gone all over the place, haven't we?

MR: We have indeed. That's what I like about interviews. You never know where you're going to go with it.

BC: We've got about twenty minutes I would guess, right?

MR: Yeah. Anything you want to talk about yourself?

BC: I want to check my last e-mail is what I want to do.

MR: Do you have favorite films? You know, like "The Godfather." Those kind of films.

BC: I wish you'd prepared me for this question.

MR: Yeah, I know it's too hard.

BC: It's hard to come up with all at once because if I say one film, I'll forget another film. I mean there are films all over the place. God if I mention some people will say well how come you didn't mention that one. I mean films like "L'Atalante."

MR: What's the name of it?

BC: "L'Atalante" — The Atlantic. It's about a tug boat. "The Conversation." I just saw a wonderful film called "Nostalgia for the Light," a film made in Chile, it was a documentary, "Last of the Blue Devils." I've got to talk about Bruce Ricker because he was the Godfather. He made "Last of the Blue Devils," and he was a lawyer in Kansas City. And he just was listening to this jazz that he loved and somehow he found some money and got some cameras and he just shot all this stuff and edited the film. Who knew that you could do jazz documentaries in 1974? The only other film before that that was a jazz documentary, there were two jazz films. There was Bert Stern, who was a fashion photographer shooting the Newport Jazz Festival, and there was Gjon Mili films about shooting Lester Young and the dancers and, what's it called?

MR: Oh yeah. He's playing and the smoke.

BC: The smoke and the dancers.

BC: And Sweets Edison is in it.

MR: I can't remember the name.

BC: He was a fashion photographer. Gjon Mili, he's Hungarian. "The Conversation" is a great film. "Whatever Happened to Gilbert Grape," Leonardo DiCaprio's first film and as far as I'm concerned by far his best film. And I'm going to not remember — Robert Altman's "Jazz 34," which is the outtakes, the outtakes of Kansas City. You know in Kansas City there's the jazz scene there, but he shot, there's something called "Kansas City 34." And it's a seventy minute film and it starts early in the day, I mean late in the day, like in the afternoon when the musicians are arriving at a club, and it ends the next morning, as the musicians pack up their instruments and go out. And it's an all-night jam session. And they had Nicholas Payton, David "Fathead" Newman, Don Byron.

MR: Cyrus Chestnut?

BC: Cyrus Chestnut, but also the woman piano player, Allen, Geri Allen playing Mary Lou Williams. Each one of them — they didn't come out and say they were these people but they were modeled on these people. And it was Kansas City the way it used to be but coming back to life. And incredible music. And one thing segued into another thing, there was no talking. I think Harry Belafonte had a little voiceover thing. But it's an incredible film. I mean it's not a documentary but it recreated, it could have almost been like a documentary. The minute you walk out of here I'm going to say why didn't I mention this, mention that.

MR: Well that was a question I should have prepared you for. What do you listen to these days as far as jazz?

BC: You know I listen to Pandora. I don't go too much out of my way to sit down and listen, though I have it on. Sometimes Pandora and I have it tuned to Clifford Brown and also to bebop, stuff comes up. I just got another car with a great stereo system and I listened to two records that just kill me. A little known album by Karl Berger, done in the early nineties. It's a semi-big-band with Enrico Rava and all sorts of people and with Ingrid Sertso singing called "No Man is an Island." I could listen to that forever. It's an incredible recording. And then I also have Howard Johnson's "Gravity." Do you know the Gravity band?

MR: Yeah.

BC: That band was four years in the making. He kept on trying to put it together and I think he released that in the mid-nineties also. It's a great album. Unbelievable solos. So that's two pieces. Let's see what else. I've got a wonderful CD, "Mingus Plays Mingus." It's Mingus playing the piano. Do you know that CD? I love that CD. And this is like something else, what do I listen to. The minute you walk out of here I'll tell you

MR: Do you think it gets harder and harder to innovate in the world of jazz?

BC: That's a good question. Wynton talks about that. Keith Jarrett talks about that. But I still — Joe Williams said this wonderful thing in the interview, he said first you imitate, then you assimilate, then you innovate. And Warren talked about that. He said, you know, I'm not sure I was an innovator. And I even heard a panel discussion at the Institute of Jazz Studies about, like Clifford was a great player, a great player. But he wasn't an innovator. The innovators are few and far between. They change the sound of the music. Miles was an innovator. Dizzy was an innovator. Dizzy changed — Louis was an innovator. He was the first one, obviously, unless you want to count Jelly Roll Morton. And then Dizzy came along and he changed all that, and then Miles changed all that, going from high technique to space and beautiful stretched out playing the way Jaki Byard was talking about. And then you know, Ornette changed the music. And I think also the other thing that you have to look at is that the classifications of music are breaking down.

MR: Um hum. Like world music and everything.

BC: Yeah. Which Karl Berger started at the Creative Music Studio. It's improvised music, and it's not improvised music. It's a combination, a re-combination of things. So yeah, I think there are innovators all the time. There may be innovators that just remind you that music is not high — that bring you back to your heart for instance. There can be one guy out there who just plays — you hear something on — I used to play in this big band and there was this kid there at the time, a trumpet player named Gregg Glassman. And I began to listen to him playing and he had no technique at first. Now he's got a lot of chops. But every solo he made came from the heart. It was like a poem coming out. And all these great trumpet players [scats] every note he played you could tell he was trying to make poetry. So there may be innovators out there that you never heard of. But if they remind you to come from your heart and not from your head, that's an innovator. And yes, the innovators, hey, the first person who came out with electronics in music, like Jay Clayton uses voice doublers and changes of voice and unchained this pure voice and she started — so there are ways to innovate — I don't see clear demarcations. Some people do something for the first time and people pick up on it. It becomes part of the vocabulary. A word that no one heard before after a while becomes part of the vocabulary.

MR: Well you and I have been able to be in the presence of some very classy people.

BC: I thank God for that.

MR: I do too. That's been the greatest part of this experience for me, is, you know, being next to people who make you feel better and make you work better and everything else.

BC: How much time do we have?

BC: I'll tell you an incredible dream I had once and I don't know if this makes it on camera or not. I once dreamt, this was a while back, that I was on this other plane of existence, and it was like a plane. It was just white everywhere. In the middle of this white was a piano, it was a Rosewood piano, it was gorgeous, and an old ancient scroll that — you know like these scrolls that you turn up for the piano? And on it was an illuminated manuscript, like the old illuminated manuscripts, the Medieval ones? And it had one page of music, just one staff. And on the staff, in the old Medieval writing with the square notes, it had the most basic triad — C-E-G. But the book was a hologram. And if you looked in it you could see the mysteries of the universe. And it was clear to me that if you sat down and played that triad with the right touch, the mysteries would be revealed. So I sat down at the piano. And as I sat down these entities, like spiritual beings in monk's robes, and they didn't walk, they glided over. And what I noticed is there was curiosity but not anticipation. There was not motion connected to it, they just wanted to see what I could do. And I sat down and I played the triad, even for me easy to play, but nothing happened. And they glided away, no disappointment. And even before I woke up I knew what the meaning of the dream was. I've been privileged enough to get into the playing of masters, because I've worked with a lot of well-known musicians in the course of what I've done, and met many, many more. So I got to their plane, but I was a long way to becoming a master. And what did it take to become a master? Just what it takes to play, I had to practice. Like Warren talks about practicing. It's not playing the notes. He had this beautiful thing about getting to the heart of the note and the intent of the music, finding the intent. That's what the dream was. That practice was not to get to the level of master, the next level was to go deeper and deeper and deeper, and that comes from practicing. And it's interesting that you used the word, because practice applies to musical practice, and it applies to spiritual practice. It's all connected.

MR: That sounds like a great way to wrap up today. It was a great image.

BC: Yeah it stayed with me.

MR: Thank you for sharing that.

BC: And now I look at that and I say have I been practicing? Not the way I should be. But we all do the best we can.

MR: All right. Well thank you, Burrill.

BC: Thank you, Monk.

MR: And it's been nice having you for a friend and a colleague.

BC: Yes, Monk, friend and colleague. I feel one of the great benefits of the Joe Williams film was we got to meet, and that's another blessing, and will continue to be. And go get Don McGlynn and get — who else should you get — I'll tell you. There are other people

making films about jazz. And right here we have Joel Katz who made the film about the lyrics to "Strange Fruit."

MR: He did that film? It was on PBS?

BC: It's called "Strange Fruit."

MR: Yeah, I have it.

BC: He's local. And he may have done that interview, he's friends with Jack DeJohnette. He may have done the interview with Jack DeJohnette that's on the web site. Because I know he's shot some footage of Jack DeJohnette in a recording session. I will pass on names of people. And by the way, they do things other than jazz but some of them have done things on jazz that are really worth seeing and talking about. And I'm glad you opened up this avenue in your archive.

MR: Yeah, I'm glad that that guy —